

OPERATIONAL STRATEGY · BASELINE

Current USBR operations

A management strategy in the COEQWAL scenario library

Regulations and policies that govern Central Valley water operations are continually evolving, meaning that the definition of “current” operations depends on the time window in which you make such a designation. This strategy represents a variation of USBR's 2024 long-term operations plan (Alternative 2 version 1), rather than the DWR operating rules encapsulated in the “Current Operations” that chronologically preceded it. This scenario is run with the same hydrology and the same 2020 land use as in “Current Operations” and similarly activates TUCP actions. Additional modifications of operating rules have occurred since December 2024 - these actions are not represented in this scenario. In the configuration table the operational difference is apparent in the biological-opinions field: the 2024 USBR consultation package in place of the 2019 Biological Opinions and 2020 ITP.

This brief describes *the representation of “current USBR operations” as a distinct scenario*, one of 28 management strategies in the COEQWAL scenario library. Each strategy is simulated once under each of five hydroclimates; the references note at the end of this brief lists the model runs.

§2 WHAT THIS STRATEGY CHANGES

The strategy replaces the operating rules of current operations with those of USBR's 2024 final Long-Term Operations (LTO) scenario Alt2 version 1 — a variation on USBR's proposed-action alternatives from the consultation with fisheries agencies that concluded in December 2024.

Actions in this configuration that differ from the COEQWAL Current Operations scenario (derived from DWR operations) include, but are not limited to, modified Shasta storage rules and CVP allocation rules oriented toward winter-run Chinook salmon, and a different internal hydrologic forecast mechanism. TUCP actions are active in this configuration, which makes it comparable to the COEQWAL Current Operations scenario.

In the eight-field table in §3 these operational differences are highlighted in a single field — the biological opinions (BiOps) — because the USBR package enters the model as a distinct consultation ruleset. The other fields remain at the same values used in the Current Operations scenario.

§3 THE CONFIGURATION IN DETAIL

The table compares the eight operational fields that define this strategy against current operations — the strategy that represents existing operational rules, recent (2020) land use, and TUCPs. Rows that match current operations are shown in light gray; rows that differ are highlighted.

ASPECT	CURRENT OPERATIONS	THIS STRATEGY
TUCP actions	Active	Active
SGMA actions	None	None
Land use	2020 LandIQ	2020 LandIQ
Delta regulations	Standard	Standard
BiOps	2019 / 2020 ITP	2024 USBR Alt2v1
Infrastructure	Standard	Standard
Flows	Standard	Standard
Allocation / priorities	Standard	Standard

§4 LINEAGE AND SOURCE

The base model code was taken from USBR's 2024 final Long-Term Operations scenario Alt2v1. The COEQWAL team replaced USBR's original hydrology (which reflected a climate centered on 2022) with DWR's adjusted historical dataset, updated agricultural demands to the 2020 LandIQ land use, and activated TUCP actions. The internal hydrologic forecasting mechanism was not modified and follows the version used in the source study from USBR. The CalSim model files for this strategy are referenced by the run IDs in the references note at the end of this brief.

§5 RELATED STRATEGIES

RELATED STRATEGIES — BASELINE

Current operations with historical land use. Current operational rules with agricultural demands set from the older 2004–2013 average land use.

Current operations. Existing operational rules with recent (2020) land use and TUCP actions — the current-operations anchor the other strategies are compared against.

Current operations without TUCPs. Current operations with TUCP actions deactivated.

Current USBR operations without TUCPs. Operating rules from USBR's 2024 Long-Term Operations plan (Alt2v1), with TUCP actions deactivated.

§6 WHAT THIS DOESN'T SAY

This brief describes a scenario representation in CalSim, not a real-world policy proposal or implementation plan. The strategy as modeled may not capture all details necessary to support direct translation to actual operations. The brief does not predict, evaluate, or recommend any outcome — it describes what the scenario changes about CalSim's representation of the system. For what the model produces under this strategy, see the result briefs referenced in §7.

§7 SEE RESULTS FOR THIS STRATEGY

To see modeled outcomes for the current-operations family across all nine sectors at the reference hydroclimate, see the *BASELINES* brief.

To see outcomes at a specific place, see the relevant LOI briefs — particularly those for Shasta reservoir, Sacramento River locations, and the export service areas.

Compare this strategy in the data explorer → (<https://coeqwal.org/explore?strategy=s0024>)

REFERENCES — MODEL RUNS

Each strategy is simulated once under each of five hydroclimates. The table lists the model run behind this strategy and the current-operations run it is compared against, for each hydroclimate, so any reader can trace this page to specific CalSim runs.

HYDROCLIMATE	THIS STRATEGY	CURRENT OPERATIONS
Historical hydroclimate (adjusted)	s0024	s0020
Moderate climate stress (EC-Earth3-Veg)	s0137	s0134
Moderate-high climate stress (cc50)	s0050	s0047
High climate stress (cc95)	s0059	s0056
Extreme climate stress (TaiESM1)	s0111	s0108

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